

na and the National Semiconductor team started becoming more and more known in the semiconductor industry.

“That sort of established a rapport with many of the semiconductor companies. I was a regular to IESA events, and when the nominations and the selection process happened, the members asked to nominate my name. Once selected for Vice Chairman, you get elevated to being Chairman during the next year,” explains Krishna.

Today, Krishna is working to bring up and foster an environment for the growth of semiconductor industry in India through IESA. Everything he has done in his professional life, from designing systems and ASICs in BEL to understanding semiconductors and ecosystem at National Semiconductor and Rambus, are being leveraged towards the growth of electronics and semiconductors in the country. The likes of Tata Group announcing their foray into the semiconductor domain recently probably says that it is time for India to get into semiconductor manufacturing, now that we are well entrenched in design.

But being a leader comes with a price, a price that you have to pay every day by trying to balance your work and life, and a price that you pay in saying no to favours to colleagues! “Work life balance becomes a very big challenge when you’re working for a multinational company. Your day starts depending on the organisation and its location. Practically, you are following the Sun, that is, 6 AM to almost midnight. But it is not the same every day,” says Krishna.

He adds, “You have to be clear about the priorities. You have to be clear about work on work-days and clear about family on non-work days. There is no ideal solution but being clear about your priorities is what’s the best you can do. There will always be work-life challenges, and upwards you move towards bigger responsibilities like being a managing director, bigger the challenges will become in terms of work-life balance.”

Not the only balance

Work-life balance is not the only balance that Krishna has to take care of as he is also the CEO of IESA, which simply means that he also has to live



K. Krishna Moorthy with his wife Shubhalakshmi, son Aswath, and daughter-in-law Bhavya

up to the expectations of all players in India’s electronics and semiconductors industry, be it MNCs, Indian corporates, incubators, startups, or MSMEs. For example, when representing to the government for a new policy, he has to ensure that IESA represents the need for growth opportunities for all, without alienating or aggrieving any of the member groups in IESA. We are in a time period when it is believed that being in India now and being in the electronics industry is once in a lifetime of opportunities.

Moreover, the government of India has shown keen interest in establishing a local ecosystem for fostering the semiconductor industry, and Krishna heading IESA needs to make sure that the requests of the industry are placed on the government’s table with accuracy, pragmatism, and transparency for favourable consideration. “It is of utmost importance to set the right expectations when you are talking to your industry members. You have to clearly convey to the industry about the policy making mechanisms and how they work. And likewise, clearly articulate to the government the short-term and long-term policy interventions needed for this sector. That is the first step,” explains Krishna about how he positions the industry association IESA.

He does not shy away from praising the central government and some state governments for the way these have functioned in the last five to six years. He is of the view that the central

government has accelerated work on many fronts including semiconductors during the last five years. So also, many state governments. “We are not a country with infinite resources and the governments have to assign priorities where it makes maximum impact. All of us need to understand this,” says Krishna.

“The present government instead of making the industry work in sync with it has started working in sync with the industry. It has already started going more than half-way. The biggest change that I feel is happening is that instead of the industry getting into a monologue with the government, there is a healthy dialogue happening between the two. Both sides approach each other with respect and clear understanding that there will be problems to understand and solve, and a sense of optimism has filled the air,” says Krishna.

And now comes the second biggest challenge, the challenge of saying no to those seeking favours. Krishna says, “Yes, people ask for favours. There are two ways of saying no. First you, from the very beginning, should create an environment around you which tells people that you are a no-nonsense guy. They should get the message that any favours asked that are ethically not correct or are favours which will only benefit a few and not the industry at large that you represent, will not get any ears,” says Krishna. He adds, “This is one practice I have followed from as early as my days with BEL.